

Free Microsoft

With free software suites such as OpenOffice eating into profits, Microsoft released Office Starter 2010 with stripped down versions of Word and Excel and excludes PowerPoint

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steps towards private cloud computing for your organisation, look for good 'appliance' versions of such offerings. These appliances are likely to be relatively cheaper, have better plug-and-play characteristics, and would typically be a fusion of proven discrete products, say a platform and an application.

9 XaaS Since any thing as a service reduces the risk of failure, it is a good bet when experimenting with new software and solutions

While software-as-a-service (SaaS) is the better known and talked about category, but there are others too – infrastructure-as-a-service, platform-as-a-service, and so on. All these services are delivered over the cloud.

In India, as elsewhere, telecom service providers are emerging as mainstream XaaS channels and providers, as part of their attempt to offset falling average revenue per user in their regular voice and data service offerings.

XaaS has largely been marketed as a pay-as-you-use or utility pricing

model, which has fueled buyer interest and adoption. However, it can be correctly argued that an enterprise-wide usage would demand contract pricing to come into play, and perhaps render the cost advantage of XaaS less obvious.

Yet, XaaS will have a clear overall advantage over box-based pricing models, despite the leasing and financing options promoted by box vendors.

IT Next's opinion is that XaaS would be a particularly good bet when experimenting with new software and solutions for non-core functions, as it lowers risks associated with failure. You may consider XaaS alternatives for proven solutions deployed in the core, only after being convinced by success studies and robust proofs of concept.

10 Enterprise-grade Social Software By plugging social media tools into an enterprise application or process, organisations can achieve 'contextual collaboration'

Have you fought against the invasion of various social media platforms into the enter-

prise, haunted by security concerns? It's time to realise that the use of social media is a cultural-cum-generational shift in human-to-human communication. The best way to defend against its perils is to embrace it, with security filters built in. That's what enterprise-grade social software is all about!

Deployment of social media in the enterprise will earn IT managers accolades, not just for providing the communication environment that employees are already used to, but more importantly for initiating a cultural shift that will help enterprises compete better in the marketplace.

A salient feature of enterprise social networking is "collaboration in context". This can be achieved by plugging in social media collaboration features into an enterprise application or process to enable information sharing between users right when the need for sharing is felt.

IT Next suggests that IT managers spend time in evaluating various enterprise-grade social media solutions and looking for success studies. Carry out the deployment only after you are convinced of the benefits. **d**

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